A Crumbling Empire

The empire was beginning to crumble. In an unprecedented move, the RAF mutinied in 1946.[1] There were a series of demonstrations and strikes at several dozen RAF stations in India and South-east Asia in January 1946. The protests arose from slow demobilisation and poor conditions of service following the end of WWII. The mutiny began at the RAF's Drigh Road station in Karachi and later spread to involve nearly 50,000 men over 60 RAF stations in India and Ceylon, including the then-largest RAF base at Cawnpore (now, Kanpur) and far-off RAF bases such as Singapore.

This contagion set the precedent and instigated subsequent mutinies undertaken by the members of the Indian Air Force first and then the navy. In February 1946, 78 out of a total of 88 ships mutinied in Bombay and Karachi.[2] Lord Wavell, the Viceroy of India at that time, conceded that both the mutinies considerably undermined the power of British authority in India. The Indian Army soldiers who revolted in Singapore in 1942 consolidated to form the INA, under the leadership of Subhash Chandra Bose. The INA had fought the British Army in Burma and north-eastern India and lost. However, an irreparable trust deficit had been created and British could no longer trust the officers of the Indian Army to sustain and preserve British rule in India. Further, IB intercepts of radio broadcasts ostensibly made by Bose in December 1945 and January 1946[3] struck fear in British intelligence circles and made them fear the consequences of Bose's army attacking them.

In the midst of all this turmoil, Attlee's cabinet took a decision in February 1947 to wind down all the country's overseas commitments that would prove difficult to sustain in the future.[4] British shipping through Suez had to be protected, along with the bases in Aden, Hong Kong and Singapore. There was a growing communist insurgency in both Malaysia and Indonesia and India's Congress party was objecting to the use of Indian troops to fight in these countries as well as in the Middle-East. The emerging Cold War in Europe entailed diversion of resources to protect western Europe and to develop a British nuclear deterrence. Something had